

SEA FAN

Some corals do not have stony skeletons, so they do not help with building the reef. Many of these soft corals are colonies of tiny, interconnected animals, just like the reef builders. They include the gorgonians (sea fans), which form branching colonies of tiny tentacled polyps that look like flattened trees growing up from the reef. They grow so that their fans face the current, increasing the chance of snaring passing food particles.



▲ CROWN-OF-THORNS

This deadly enemy of coral can grow to more than 12 in (30 cm) across. The starfish shown here has unusually bright colors.

CREEPING KILLER

The crown-of-thorns starfish has up to 21 arms bristling with long, sharp, venom-soaked spines. It feeds on living coral by turning its stomach inside-out through its central mouth to drench its prey with toxic digestive juices. These turn the coral to soup, which the starfish slowly sucks up. Sometimes swarms of these starfish overrun coral reefs, devouring the living corals and leaving behind just their dead, stony skeletons.

PUNCHING PREDATOR

The colorful mantis shrimp that live on the reef are fearsome predators. Some have claws armed with sharp, barbed tips that they use to spear passing fish. Others have clublike claws that help to crack the shells of other shellfish, punching into them with such force that the shellfish are killed instantly.



WOW!

The peacock mantis shrimp has claws that can smash into a victim at a speed of 50 mph (80 kph)—the fastest punch of any animal.

DEADLY SNAIL

The tubular snout of a cone shell is armed with a venomous harpoon of incredible power. The poison of the bigger species can kill a human. The cone uses the venom to attack and kill small fish, which it then swallows whole. Many of the 600 different species live on tropical coral reefs.



◀ PEACOCK MANTIS SHRIMP

A relative of lobsters, this mantis shrimp lives on coral reefs in the western Pacific and Indian oceans. It hides in a burrow dug in coral sand.

▲ TEXTILE CONE

One of the bigger, more dangerous cone shells, the textile cone lives on coral reefs throughout the Pacific and Indian oceans, where it preys mainly on fish living on the seafloor.